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Hari Ranjan Rao: India has the infrastructure for hosting Olympics, CWG

India already has the capability to host an event on the scale of the Olympics, said Hari Ranjan Rao (second from left), IAS, Secretary, Sports, Government of India, at *Sportstar's PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit*.

"If you look at infrastructure building for hosting a multi-sport event like the Olympics and Commonwealth Games, India has already done it and proven it in the past.

"The infrastructure that was built at that time is still there and being put to use by athletes and various stakeholders.

"So, to my mind, creating infrastructure for hosting a multi-sport event is not a childhood dream. Especially where the country is today in terms of the growth curve," Rao said.

"There is a good case for putting our heads together and coming up with ways in which we could spend this money in a more nuanced, fruitful and useful way. In the typical sporting language, spending money

on the field of play is more important than building huge, large-scale concrete stadiums that you will never be able to fill in one or two years," he said.

Achanta Sharath Kamal (left), former paddler and vice chairperson of the Indian Olympic Association Athletes Commission, underlined that building a competitive talent pool for the 2036 Olympics was also a priority.

"Getting the Olympics [hosting rights] is one goal, but if you plug everything in place from grassroots to high performance for the next 10 to 12 years, you will get athletes who will be at their peak by 2036. This is the generation we're looking to nurture. This will have a snowball

effect where kids will have a way of life through sport," he said during the panel 'Gameplan 2036: India's Global Event Ambition', moderated by K.C. Vijaya Kumar, Sports Editor, *The Hindu*.

Paralympic Committee of India president and former para-athlete Devendra Jhajharia (second from right) echoed that India has both the experience and the capacity to host the Games. "An international delegation had visited us during the first edition of the Khelo India Para Games. When they saw the facilities, they said that India can host an international event very well. So, I would like to tell you that India is ready to host the Olympics. We can do it easily. We have the capacity," he said.

Both Jhajharia and Sharath expressed confidence in India's para-athletes when the Olympics eventually come home.

"We will be performing above expectations. In Paris, we were 18th. Mark my words, we will be in the top 10 at the home Olympics," Jhajharia said.

